

Time Allocation in System Design Interview (45–60 min)

System design interviews are **time-constrained** and **broad in scope**, so proper time management is critical.

You cannot design everything — you must **prioritize structure over completeness**.

Overall Idea

None

Total Interview Time $\approx$ 45–60 minutes

Goal = Cover all 4 steps without rushing deep design or skipping clarity

Step-wise Time Distribution

Step 1: Understand Problem & Define Scope

None

3 – 10 minutes

Focus:

- Clarify requirements
- Ask key questions
- Define system boundaries
- Confirm assumptions

Most important: **Do NOT jump into design here**

Step 2: High-Level Design & Buy-In

None

10 – 15 minutes

Focus:

- Create system architecture (Figure-based flow if needed)
- Identify major components
- Get interviewer feedback
- Adjust design collaboratively

Goal: Build **shared understanding of system**

Step 3: Deep Dive Design

None

10 – 25 minutes

Focus:

- Analyze critical components
- Discuss trade-offs
- Handle bottlenecks
- Optimize performance

This is the **most flexible and important step**

Examples:

- Caching strategy
- Database design
- Message queues
- Scaling approach

Step 4: Wrap Up

None

3 – 5 minutes

Focus:

- Identify bottlenecks
- Suggest improvements
- Discuss failure handling
- Summarize design
- Talk about scalability

End with strong **engineering maturity**

Time Distribution Summary

Step	Focus Area	Time
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Step 1	Requirements & Scope	3–10 min
Step 2	High-Level Design	10–15 min
Step 3	Deep Dive	10–25 min
Step 4	Wrap-Up	3–5 min

Key Insight

None

System design success = Not how much you design, but how well you manage time across clarity, architecture, depth, and closure

Important Notes

- Time allocation is **flexible, not fixed**
- Adjust based on interviewer interest
- If interviewer spends more time in Step 3 → compress Step 2
- Always keep Step 4 (wrap-up) intact

Mental Model

None

Understand → Design → Deep Dive → Summarize

(10%)

(30%)

(50%)

(10%)

One-Line Summary

System design interviews are time-bound; optimal performance comes from spending ~10% on requirements, ~30% on high-level design, ~50% on deep dive, and ~10% on wrap-up.